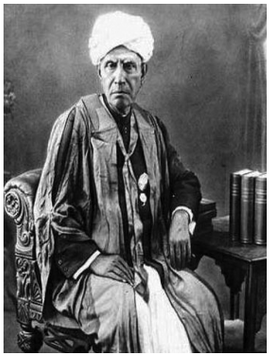
Advent of the Printing Technology

Tamil was the first non-European language that went into print. As early as in 1578, Tamil book, *Thambiran Vanakkam*, was published from Goa. In 1709, a full-fledged printing press had been established thanks to Ziegenbalg in Tranquebar. *Thirukkural* was one of the earliest Tamil literary texts to be published in 1812. This led the resurgence of interest among Tamil scholars in publishing the more ancient Tamil classics around that period.


Ziegenbalg

In the nineteenth century, Tamil scholars like C.W. Damotharanar (1832–1901), and U.V. Swaminathar (1855–1942) spent their lifetime in the rediscovery of the Tamil classics. C. W. Damotharanar collected and edited different palm-leaf manuscripts of the Tamil grammar and literature. His editions included such texts as *Tolkappiyam*, *Viracholiyam*, *Iraiyanar-Akapporul*, *Ilakkana Vilakkam*, *Kaliththokai* and *Chulamani*. U.V. Swaminathar, a student of Meenakshisundaranar, took efforts to publish the classical texts such as *Civakachinthamani* (1887), *Paththupattu* (1889), *Chilapathikaram* (1892), *Purananuru* (1894), *Purapporul-Venpa-Malai* (1895), *Manimekalai* (1898), *Ainkurunuru* (1903) and *Pathitrupathu*(1904).


C.W. Damotharanar


U.V. Swaminathar

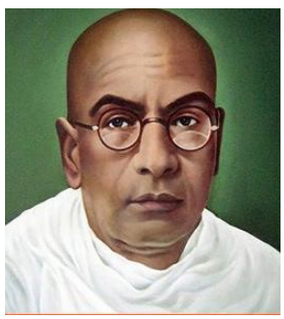
The publication of these ancient literary texts created an awareness among the Tamil people about their historical tradition, language, literature and religion. Modern Tamils founded their social and cultural identity on the ancient Tamil classics, collectively called the Sangam literature.


Robert Caldwell

In 1816, F.W. Ellis (1777–1819) who founded the College of Fort St George, formulated the theory that the south Indian languages belonged to a separate family which was unrelated to the Indo-Aryan family of languages. Robert Caldwell (1814–1891) expanded this argument in a book titled, *A Comparative Grammar of the Dravidian or South Indian Family of Languages*, in 1856. He established the close affinity between the Dravidian languages in contrast with Sanskrit and also established the antiquity of Tamil.


P. Sundaranar

Tamil intellectuals of this period identified the fundamental differences between Tamil/Dravidian/ Egalitarian and Sanskrit/ Aryan/Brahmanism. They argued that Tamil was a language of Dravidian people, who are non-Brahmin and their social life was casteless, gender-sensitised and egalitarian. Tamil renaissance contributed to the origin and growth of Dravidian consciousness in the Tamil country. These ideas are exemplified in the Tamil invocation song in the play, *Manonmaniam* written by P. Sundaranar (1855–1897).


Thiru. Vi. Ka


Bharatidasan

Ramalinga Adigal (1823–1874), popularly known as Vallalar, questioned the existing

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